Do you want to break open your head?' asked Ammamma. 'What if I never see my folks again. . . My Guruvayoorappa! I'll never see them again!' 'You can go home tomorrow morning, as soon as the rain stops. All right?' said Muthassi. 'This rain will never stop. It's a whirlwind, isn't it? We'll all die,' sobbed the woman.

'Is she crazy?' asked Muthassi. We heard trees crashing to the ground. And a dog whining in the western yard. 'Aiyo, Sankara! What if the cowshed crumbles? Bring the cows in and tie them up in the washing area outside the kitchen,' said Ammamma. 'The cowshed won't fall down, Valiamma. Its beams are quite strong,' said Sankaran Nair, who had gone to check things out. 'Then let the cows stay there.'

'There's knee-deep water in the yard now,' said Sankaran. 'We want to swim,' I cried. 'You can swim in the courtyard of the nalukettu,' said Ettan. I put my hand into the water in the courtyard. 'It's ice-cold.' I grumbled. 'Don't play in the water, children,' Ammamma called out loudly. We climbed back on the bed. Someone seemed to be knocking on the door on the southern side. Sanakaran opened it. A dog stood on the verandah, dripping wet-Thumbi, the black-and-white pet dog from Ambazhathel.

'Look, here's Thumbi. 'He's drenched. Poor thing, he must have come out with Balamani Amma', said Sankaran. We looked at Thumbi and he looked at us. He was shivering in the cold. Sankaran spread a gunny bag on the verandah. 'Lie down on this. In a storm like this, how can we make a difference between a man and a dog? Go to sleep, Thumbi.' Thumbi lay down on the gunny bags and looked contentedly at me and my brother. We spent the whole night in the southern room. By the time we woke up, the rain had stopped.

It was the sound of a pleading voice saying 'Please open the gate' that actually woke me. A young man stood smiling in the waist-high water at the gate. 'I'm from Vadekkara. Is everyone here all right?' 'Yes,' said Ammamma. 'We've had no casualties. How did you come, Balan?' 'I started out at daybreak and waded through the water.' 'That's really smart!' 'The number of huts and trees that have collapsed! Fowls lying dead everywhere, dead goats floating in the water -- what a sight!' 'Come in, Balan, and change your mundu.'

'Have they sent us anything from Vadekkara? Murukkus or dates?' I asked. 'No, child. I've come empty-handed,' said Balan, displaying his buck teeth. 'What a time to ask for murukkus and dates!' muttered Ammaman's mother. I hung my head, ashamed.

GLOSSARY

Kamala Das

In Malayalam		In English	In Malayalam		In English
Edathi	-	brother's wife	thekkini	-	backyard
Ettan	-	elder brother	Ammayi	-	mother-in-law
Ammamma	-	mother's mother	Cheriamma	-	chitti (in Tamil)
Muthassi	-	father's mother	Ammaman	-	maternal uncle

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